relations after Russia's annexation of Crimea in 2014 (or its reunification with Russia, in the Russian version) altered the landscape. As NATO and G7 sought to isolate Russia politically, India withstood US pressure to join this effort. India opposed initiatives to expel Russia from the G20 multilateral grouping, supported Russia's activities in Brazil–Russia–India–China–South Africa (BRICS), and accepted Russia's (and China's) invitation to join the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation.

India publicly rejected participation in the West's economic sanctions against Russia, which included restrictions on technology transfers and trade with the Russian defence and hydrocarbons industries. This stand became more problematic in 2017, when the United States moved from primary sanctions (which applies only to entities and currencies of the sanctions imposing countries) to secondary sanctions, authorised by the Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act (CAATSA), whereby any entity anywhere in the world that entered into "significant" defence transactions or major energy pipelines projects with Russia could be barred from business in the United States or with US companies. The Trump administration sought to tighten the economic screws on Russia and its trading partners, including India and European countries, through public threats to invoke CAATSA.

While the India–China economic engagement continued to strengthen (albeit with increasing Indian complaints about Chinese protectionism), the political relationship deteriorated progressively after 2008, as Chinese assertiveness in its region extended to aggressive political and economic activities in India's neigh-bourhood. The special representatives' discussions on the boundary did not make substantive progress after China reneged (as per India's reckoning) on a crucial provision of their agreement by reviving its claim to Arunachal Pradesh (which it calls